

2. Chamorro Months (20 marks)

Problem designed by Monojit Choudhury

After finishing her undergraduate degree in mathematics, Ms. Vibhashini wanted to explore the world. She took up a job of teaching English in a primary school in the island of Guam located in the Pacific Ocean. One day, in the class, she asked her students to write down the names of the months in English. However, she was surprised to see that 10 year old Tasi, who is a native of the island and speaks Chamorro at home, came up with a list of 23 months:

<i>Abrit</i>	<i>Hulio</i>	<i>Maimu'</i>	<i>Oktubri</i>	<i>Umagahaf</i>
<i>Agosto</i>	<i>Huño</i>	<i>Makmamao</i>	<i>Semu</i>	<i>Umatalaf</i>
<i>Disembre</i>	<i>Ineru</i>	<i>Måtsu</i>	<i>Sumongsong</i>	<i>Umayanggan</i>
<i>Fananaf</i>	<i>Lumamlam</i>	<i>Måyu</i>	<i>Tenhos</i>	
<i>Fangualu</i>	<i>Lumuhu</i>	<i>Nubembre</i>	<i>Tumaiguini</i>	

Vibhashini asked Tasi what were these. None of them were the names of the months she was expecting. Tasi told her that his grandmother tells him that there are 13 months and he learnt the names of those months. But then his parents use some other month names, some of which he remembers as well. Tasi was confused as to which month names his teacher wanted. Therefore, he wrote all the 13 names that his grandmother taught him, as well as 10 more month names that he could remember that his parents use. But he'd mixed all of them up.

Vibhashini looked at the names again, and smiled at Tasi. She knew what he was talking about and which months he missed out. She helped Tasi remember those missing names, even though she did not know Chamorro. Can you separate out the 13 month names used by Tasi's grandmother from the 10 that his parents use?

Assignment 1 [Answer-Booklet]: Identify the 10 months that Tasi has heard from his parents and write their English equivalents?

Assignment 2 [Answer-Booklet]: What are the two missing month names in Chamorro? What are their English equivalents? [No explanations needed for parts 1 and 2]

Assignment 3: Why do you think Tasi's grandmother and his parents use a different set of names for the months?

Note: Chamorro is an Austronesian language spoken by about 47,000 people who are the indigenous people of Guam and the Northern Mariana Islands, US territories. *u'* and *å* are vowels, *ñ* is a consonant.